

# THE OVERLAPPING GAME: HOW COMBINING COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS CAN LEAD TO BETTER ESSAYS IN LESS TIME

You know that expression, “A stitch in time saves nine?” This is that stitch.

In this post I’m basically going to ask you to gather all your college essay prompts, then spend just 10-20 minutes looking for instances where they might overlap. By doing so you’ll save tons of time and write better essays.

Why?

Because writing an essay that works for several prompts leads to essays that have much more *elasticity* (as in: they can stretch to fit multiple prompts), which often means they have more depth.

For example, writing an essay about your improv comedy troupe could probably work for both of these prompts (bold emphasis below is ours):

*Michigan: Everyone belongs to many different communities and/or groups defined by (among other things) shared geography, religion, ethnicity, income, cuisine, interest, race, ideology, or intellectual heritage. **Choose one of the communities to which you belong, and describe that community and your place within it.***

*Duke: We seek a diverse student body that embodies the wide range of human experience. In that context, we are interested in **what you’d like to share about your lived experiences and how they’ve influenced how you think of yourself.***

Want to save yourself even more time? Look for MORE prompts your topic could work for. Take this one, for example:

*Stanford: Tell us about something that is meaningful to you and why.*

That same essay could work for this prompt too, right? Plus, now Stanford is going to not only learn about why improv comedy is meaningful to you, but

also how it's created a kind of community for you (thanks to Michigan) AND how it has equipped you with a unique perspective (thanks to Duke).

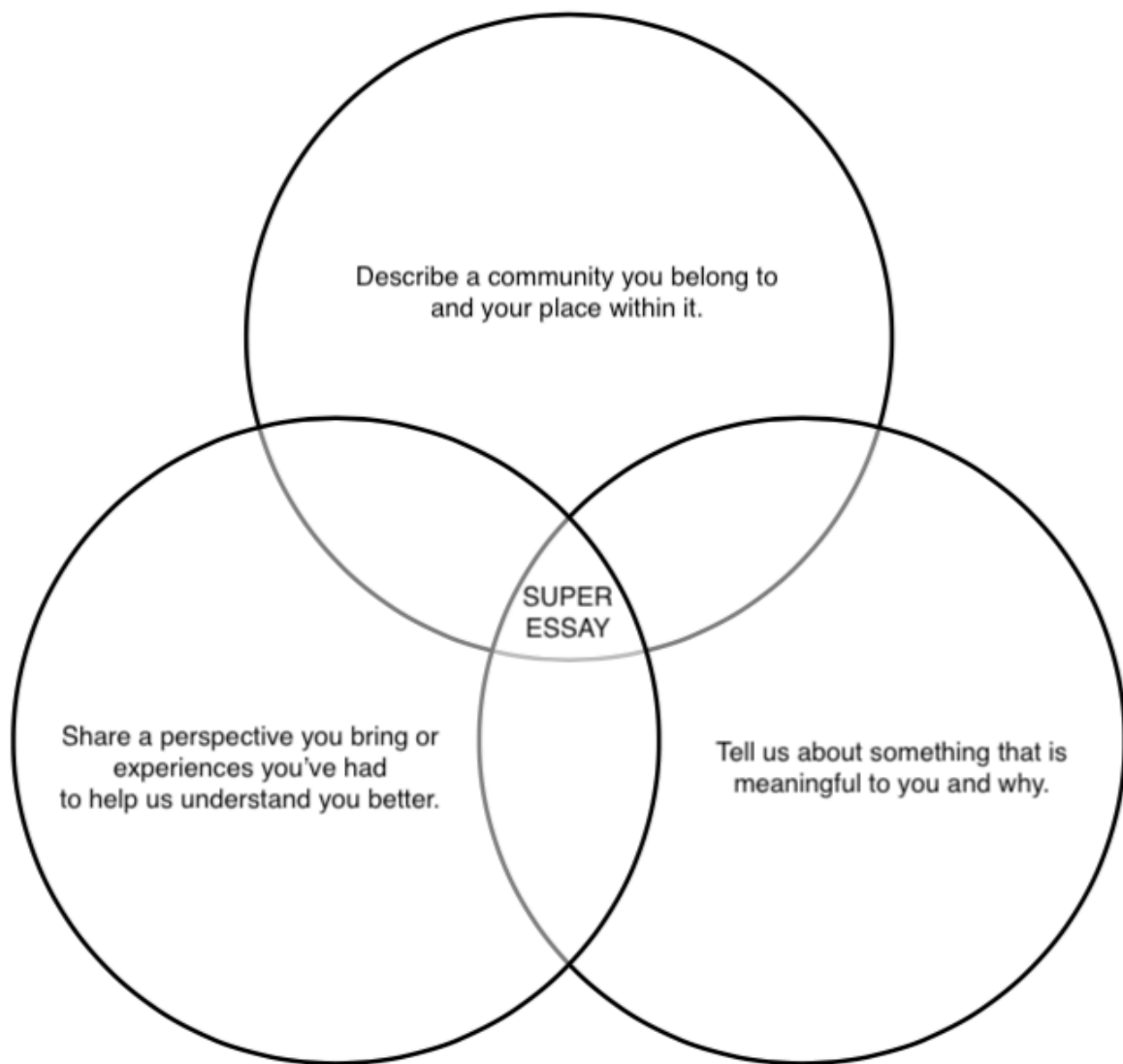
So what are we doing here?

We're brainstorming what I call *Super Essays*.

Check it out:

## **MEET THE SUPER ESSAY**

The Super Essay *not only* answers the prompt, *but also* tells the reader something more. Here's a Venn Diagram to illustrate based on the Michigan/Duke/Stanford example above, but remember that this can be applied to any schools that have overlapping prompts:



*Venn Diagram of a Super Essay Topic*

## **HOW TO WRITE A SUPER ESSAY: A STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE**

**STEP #1: COLLECT ALL YOUR COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS IN YOUR  
ESSAY TRACKER.**

How?

1. Develop your college list. I've put together a few detailed resources for list development: here's one that's in [podcast form](#) and another is in [this blog post](#). Once you've done that, come back here.
2. Gather your college essay prompts for all of your colleges. Hop onto the [Common App](#) to do that. (Be sure to double check the prompts are correct when the Common App is released on August 1st!)
3. Paste them into an [Essay Tracker](#), which is basically a simple spreadsheet with all the supplemental essays you'll need to write.

## **STEP #2: CHOOSE 2-4 ROCKSTAR ACHIEVEMENTS OR PASSION PROJECTS THAT MIGHT WORK AS A POTENTIAL "SUPER TOPIC."**

What's that, you ask? It's a topic that could potentially work for multiple prompts.

**How do you find a Super Topic?** Look to your brag sheet, resume, or Activities List. Chances are, you'll find a great topic there. If this isn't working for you, choose something that:

You've spent a LOT of time doing

AND

Is either awesomely impressive (like a research internship) OR interesting/weird (like leading historical hikes)

AND

Is NOT something you've already written about in your main statement.

That's a potential super topic. Take a few minutes now to come up with 2-3 options.

If you still can't think of anything, try asking yourself these questions (which are basically the UC Personal Insight Question topics)...

1. Describe an example of your leadership experience in which you have positively influenced others, helped resolve disputes, or contributed to group efforts over time.

2. Every person has a creative side, and it can be expressed in many ways: problem solving, original and innovative thinking, and artistically, to name a few. Describe how you express your creative side.
3. What would you say is your greatest talent or skill? How have you developed and demonstrated that talent over time?
4. Describe how you have taken advantage of a significant educational opportunity or worked to overcome an educational barrier you have faced.
5. Describe the most significant challenge you have faced and the steps you have taken to overcome this challenge. How has this challenge affected your academic achievement?
6. Think about an academic subject that inspires you. Describe how you have furthered this interest inside and/or outside of the classroom.
7. What have you done to make your school or your community a better place?

**Examples of Super Topics:** Robotics Club, drumming, developing an app, improv comedy, ice skating, teaching science to middle schoolers, Officer Cadet School, computer programming, working in a restaurant as a server, working in a garden, Model United Nations, art-making, Volunteering for American Youth Soccer Organization, love of History & Film, being an amazing cook, internship at local hospital, acapella singing, advocating for worker rights...

Get the idea here? In short, the range is pretty broad. Once you have 1-4 potential Super Topics in mind...

**STEP #3: IN THE “TOPICS” COLUMN OF YOUR ESSAY TRACKER,  
NOTE WHICH TOPICS MIGHT WORK FOR WHICH PROMPTS.**

Let’s say, for example, you picked “hiking” as a potential super topic.

And let’s say your college essay prompt list looks something like this:

1. In the space available discuss the significance to you of the school or summer activity in which you have been most involved. (1/2 page)

2. Briefly describe a non-academic pursuit (such as service to community or family, a club or sport, or work, etc.,) that best illustrates who you are, and why it is important to you. (250 words)
3. Please briefly elaborate on one of your extracurricular activities or work experiences (150 words)
4. Everyone belongs to many different communities and/or groups defined by (among other things) shared geography, religion, ethnicity, income, cuisine, interest, race, ideology, or intellectual heritage. Choose one of the communities to which you belong, and describe that community and your place within it. (250 words)
5. We're seeking a talented, engaged student body that embodies the wide range of human experience; we believe that the diversity of our students makes our community stronger. If you'd like to share a perspective you bring or experiences you've had to help us understand you better... we encourage you to do so. (250 words)

Ask yourself: for which of these topics could “hiking” potentially work?

Take a minute to actually think about this.

The answer is: it can work for them all, of course. Don't believe me? Keep reading.

**Heads-up:** this technique of writing essays for multiple prompts works for scholarship essays too. In fact, our friends at [Going Merry](#) have created scholarship bundles (called MerryApps) that combine multiple scholarships with the same essay topic and lets you apply for them all at once!

#### **STEP #4: BRAINSTORM AND WRITE A SUPER ESSAY, WHICH IS AN ESSAY THAT WORKS FOR ALL THE PROMPTS YOU'VE IDENTIFIED.**

Here's an example Super Essay:

##### **The Hiking Essay**

I'm a history nerd, to the point where I would be that guy reading history textbooks for fun. However, reading about history can only go so far. Through Boy Scouts, I have been able to arrange and lead Historical Trail hikes, giving myself and my troop first hand perspectives on what it felt like to sleep at Valley Forge in the winter, or what the walk up Breed's Hill along Boston's Freedom Trail is really like. Naturally, I became the troop “story-teller” along these hikes, adding my own tidbits of information such as pointing out

Eisenhower's five-star general flag waving from his personal putting green in Gettysburg, or how Spuyten Duyvil was perhaps named following one of the first reported shark attacks in America.

Organizing these historical hikes has also given me the opportunity to teach younger Scouts about various Scouting skills, from orienteering (using a map and compass) to conservation principles like Leave-No- Trace. My troop engages in trail maintenance projects, and we actively monitor a trail we adopted from the NY/NJ Trail Conference.

I especially relished the opportunity to apply what I had learned in AP Biology towards actually helping preserve the environment. It is one thing to learn about pollution, global warming, and invasive species in a classroom; it is another thing entirely to see the biodiversity of an ecosystem quickly succumb to man- made pressures.

Finally, hiking with the Boy Scouts has given me the chance to help others experience the beauty of the outdoors. On a recent hike, a new Scout, Louis, confided in me how disconnected he felt away from his video games. I stayed with Louis for the remainder of the hike and pointed out everything from milkweed stalks to coyote scat. After the hike, Louis was exhausted but had a glimmer of excitement towards the environment around him, and could even tell the difference between poison ivy and Virginia creeper. Louis is currently one of my troop's most active younger Scouts.

When I'm hiking, I'm not merely a hiker; I'm a historian, a conservationist, and a teacher all in one.

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I love this essay. Notice how it answers all the prompts above.

This wasn't by accident. Here's how he did it:

| Activity: Hiking                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WHAT I DID                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | PROBLEMS I SOLVED                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | LESSONS LEARNED/SKILLS I GAINED                                                                                                                                       | IMPACT I HAD                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | HOW I APPLIED WHAT I LEARNED                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Arranged and led Historical Trail hikes</li> <li>Provided first hand perspectives on what it felt like to sleep at Valley Forge in the winter.</li> <li>Told stories to scout mates about the history that surrounded us</li> <li>Mentored scouts on how to orienteer and conserve the environment around us (Leave <u>no trace</u>)</li> <li>Maintained trail we adopted</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Helped preserve the environment, specifically a trail we adopted</li> <li>Applied the lessons of biology to conservation</li> <li>Mentored new scouts who were unfamiliar with hiking and the dangers/joys that come with it</li> <li>The disconnect that one Cub Scout (Louis) felt after leaving his video games</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>The beauty of the outdoors</li> <li>The joy of mentoring others</li> <li>The value of disconnecting from technology</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Spread the importance of preserving history through stories among peers</li> <li>Mentored peers in developing scouting skills and appreciation of preserving the environment</li> <li>Helped Louis connect more closely with nature</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Connected w/History class even more</li> <li>Made me a better (academic) tutor</li> <li>Taught me how other seemingly-unrelated subjects (ex: music w/science) could be connected</li> </ul> |

Here are some tips for each column:

| Activity: [Name it here]      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                        |                                                                                                  |                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WHAT I DID                    | PROBLEMS I SOLVED                                                                                                                                                                                                            | LESSONS LEARNED/SKILLS I GAINED        | IMPACT I HAD                                                                                     | HOW I APPLIED WHAT I LEARNED                                                                         |
| The key here is active verbs. | These problems could be: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Personal</li> <li>- Family</li> <li>- Local</li> <li>- Community</li> <li>- School</li> <li>- State-level</li> <li>- National</li> <li>- Global</li> </ul> | Tip: Use the Values Exercise for this! | This is super important.<br><br>Tip: Use numbers and actual quotes to support your bullet points | How did you apply lessons from the activity *beyond* the activity itself?<br><br>See examples below. |



# 25 QUESTIONS TO HELP YOU BRAINSTORM CONTENT FOR YOUR SUPER ESSAY

(Otherwise known as the BEABIES Exercise)

What I Did (Day-to-Day):

Did I list all my tasks, or just a few? What'd I forget? Go back and check.

Did I list things I did that may have been outside the scope of my responsibilities?

Did I leave off any awards? Any uncommon achievements?

Problems I Solved:

Did I consider the internal problems I solved--any personal challenges?

Did I name the external problems I solved--for my friends or family?

School? Community?

Was I tackling a much larger (perhaps global) problem?

Lessons I Learned & Values/Skills I Developed:

What were some of the soft skills I learned (patience, communication, etc.)?

Did I learn any specific software (Photoshop, Final Cut Pro)?

Languages (Spanish, C++)? Survival skills (how to start a fire or clean a fish)?

What am I better at now than I was before?

What would I have done differently?

Impact I Had (On Self, School, Community and/or Society)

Did I consider the impact this had on my family? Friends? School? Who else benefited?

What impact did this have on me personally? Did this change my life/perspective? How?

Applications to Other Parts of School/Life:

What skills did I develop and lessons did I learn that will make me a better X (tutor, debater, advocate, volunteer, programmer, fill in the blank)? How so?

What did I do to build on and take what I learned to the next level?

What surprised me about this experience?

Okay, your turn.

**Instructions:** Choose a potential Super Topic and spend 10-15 minutes filling out a BEABIES chart using the questions listed above. By the end you should have enough content for a Super Essay.

| Activity:  |                   |                                 |              |                              |
|------------|-------------------|---------------------------------|--------------|------------------------------|
| WHAT I DID | PROBLEMS I SOLVED | LESSONS LEARNED/SKILLS I GAINED | IMPACT I HAD | HOW I APPLIED WHAT I LEARNED |
|            |                   |                                 |              |                              |

Here's one more BEABIES example:

| Example Activity: Chinese Dance Club                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WHAT I DID                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | PROBLEMS I SOLVED                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | LESSONS LEARNED/SKILLS I GAINED                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | IMPACT I HAD                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | HOW I APPLIED WHAT I LEARNED                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <p>Practiced every Sunday morning for 2.5 hours for 9 years.</p> <p>Performed at Chinese New Year festivals for 9 years.</p> <p>Danced in junior group for four years, senior group for five years, senior small group for three years.</p> <p>Served as club treasurer, managing club-related funds and handling reimbursements.</p> <p>Organized fundraiser at the Chinese Dragon Boat festival that raised over \$2000 for the club.</p> <p>Served as club Vice President.</p> <p>Won Honorable Mention at the Chinese School Association in the United States (CSAUS).</p> | <p>Feeling disconnected from Chinese culture and community.</p> <p>Not much connection to relatives in China.</p> <p>Club was struggling to maintain steady funds.</p> <p>Improving technique and artistry in Chinese dancing.</p> <p>Difficulty transitioning to Chinese dancing from ballet.</p> <p>Difficulty articulating ideas and thoughts.</p> <p>Our community lacked Chinese cultural events.</p> | <p>Became more goal-oriented.</p> <p>Managed and kept record of thousands of dollars.</p> <p>Learned...<br/>...to articulate and explain my thoughts to younger dancers.</p> <p>...how to handle conflicting interests from group leaders and dancers' parents.</p> <p>...our surrounding community is actually open to supporting our group.</p> <p>...to express my individuality in a way that I didn't with ballet.</p> <p>...every movement and pose has its own nuances.</p> <p>...how to choreograph and adapt a dance based on material from past dance groups and videos.</p> <p>...to remain patient and forgiving while teaching.</p> | <p>Grew closer to the values of Chinese culture, as there is always a story behind every dance.</p> <p>Relatives in China watched links to my dances, allowing us to connect more on phone calls.</p> <p>Developed a sense of community within the group of dancers and parents.</p> <p>Showed beauty of Chinese culture to local community.</p> | <p>Used teaching skills while tutoring peers in Chemistry.</p> <p>Lessons in leadership helped me manage board members in my club.</p> <p>Continued to reach out to my community about other causes I cared deeply about, helping to fundraise for annual event.</p> <p>Helped me become more expressive and seek other outlets of expression.</p> |

Are you with me so far? Moving on.

You won't know for sure which topic is your "best" topic as this process is more art than science. As I mentioned above, you're looking for the topic that is most *elastic* (i.e. - fits several prompts). Here's one way to do this:

Spend 10 minutes doing the **Essence Objects** exercise and ask yourself:

Could any of these objects or topics potentially connect to multiple themes?

For example: Maybe you wrote down "ballet slippers." Maybe that makes you think of all of the time you've spent not only training, but also learning about

the cultural origins of ballet... Not only that, but how might you track the intergenerational history of ballet dancers in your family?

See what we're doing here? Trying to make those essence objects (and the topics they represent) more *elastic* to fit a greater range of prompts.

So try this quick exercise: go through your most meaningful essence objects hashtag them with as many values as you can think of.

Example: ballet slippers #hardwork #culture #family #nopainnogain #health

Another example: Paul Farmer's *Mountains Beyond Mountains* #internship #inspiration #career #community #failure #humor

If you're having trouble thinking of values, [here's a list](#) to get you started.

**Now do this:** Look over each of your prompts and ask, "Could my favorite topic [whatever you've decided that is] work for this prompt... or this one... or that other one?"

For example, if you wrote solar panel software for a project in a water-scarce community in Libya, there might be connections to any prompt that has the word "culture" or "challenge" or, of course, "extracurricular" and voila: you can write one essay for all three (or four, or six) prompts.

Have fun with this! See how many you can make one topic work for. And spend as much time as you need to do this because this is what will save you the most time in your college essay process.

But wait.

You might be thinking:

*What if I'm stretching too far?*

*What if the topic I'm choosing connects to the theme but, like, in a really weird way?*

Fair point.

I believe that unusual connections are okay. But your connection to the prompt—to each prompt, in fact—has to be super clear. This may mean tweaking a sentence or two to clearly answer each different prompt. (Fun fact: usually those tweaks make the essay better anyway. That's like the whole

thing we're doing here.) But make the tweaks so you're clearly answering the prompt. If you can't, your topic may not be elastic enough. So try another topic for that prompt; the goal here isn't to find a single topic for every single prompt, but to find one that works for several.

An exception to this game is if the topic is extremely specific, as can sometimes be the case for college essay prompts that ask you to reflect on a quotation or questions like U Chicago's supplemental essay prompts or Virginia's "Describe one of your quirks and why it is part of who you are" (although that one can double with MIT or Caltech).

In short, making unusual connections will make your topic stand out, flex your creativity, and show multiple sides of you at once.

## **EXAMPLES OF COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS THAT COULD POTENTIALLY OVERLAP:**

Below are some more examples of prompts from past years that students could have answered using the Super Essay approach.

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year). We're leaving them because they nicely illustrate how much time you can save by playing this game.

### **POP QUIZ! PLAY THE OVERLAPPING GAME!**

Instructions: Below are a few more prompts. Which ones could you imagine overlapping with some of the prompts above, or with your own potential "super" topic?

1. Reflect on something that has given you great satisfaction. Why has it been important to you? -Yale University
2. Describe how your experiences, perspectives, talents, and/or your involvement in leadership activities (at your school, job, community, or

within your family) will help you to make an impact both in and out of the classroom while enrolled at UT. -University of Texas

3. Every person has a creative side, and it can be expressed in many ways: problem solving, original and innovative thinking, and artistically, to name a few. Describe how you express your creative side. -UC Personal Insight Question
4. The Stanford community is deeply curious and driven to learn in and out of the classroom. Reflect on an idea or experience that makes you genuinely excited about learning. -Stanford University
5. When was the last time you questioned something you had thought to be true? -Emory University
6. Brown's culture fosters a community in which students challenge the ideas of others and have their ideas challenged in return, promoting a deeper and clearer understanding of the complex issues confronting society. This active engagement in dialogue is as present outside the classroom as it is in academic spaces. Tell us about a time you were challenged by a perspective that differed from your own. How did you respond? -Brown
7. Think about an academic subject that inspires you. Describe how you have furthered this interest inside and/or outside of the classroom. -UC Personal Insight Question

Oh, and you know those "Why us" essays? You can also re-use content for those, but how to do that is the topic of a completely separate post.

And if you're confused, I'm basically talking about prompts like these:

### **'WHY THIS COLLEGE' ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. What is it about Yale that has led you to apply? -Yale University
2. If you selected one of the computer science or engineering majors, please tell us more about what has led you to an interest in this field of study, what experiences (if any) you have had in engineering, and what it is about Yale's Engineering program that appeals to you. -Yale University

3. Describe how you plan to pursue your academic interests at USC. Please feel free to address your first- and second-choice major selections. -University of Southern California (USC)
4. How does the University of Chicago, as you know it now, satisfy your desire for a particular kind of learning, community, and future? Please address with some specificity your own wishes and how they relate to UChicago. -University of Chicago
5. With the understanding that the choice of academic school you indicated is not binding, explain why you are applying to that particular school of study. -Rice University
6. In 300 words or less, help us understand how you might engage specific resources, opportunities, and/or communities here. We are curious about what these specifics are, as well as how they may enrich your time at Northwestern and beyond. -Northwestern University
7. Describe the unique qualities that attract you to the specific undergraduate College or School (including preferred admission and dual degree programs) to which you are applying at the University of Michigan. How would that curriculum support your interests? -University of Michigan
8. Why do you want to study your chosen major specifically at Georgia Tech? -Georgia Tech
9. If you are applying to the Trinity College of Arts and Sciences as a first year applicant, please discuss why you consider Duke a good match for you. Is there something particular about Duke that attracts you? (Please limit your response to no more than 150 words.) -Duke University
10. Why are you interested in attending Columbia University? We encourage you to consider the aspect(s) that you find unique and compelling about Columbia. -Columbia University
11. Many students pursue college for a specific degree, career opportunity or personal goal. Whichever it may be, learning will be critical to achieve your ultimate goal. As you think ahead to the process of learning during your college years, how will you define a successful college experience? -Carnegie Mellon University
12. Please tell us why BU is a good fit for you and what specifically has led you to apply for admission. -Boston University
13. Considering the specific undergraduate school you have selected, describe how you intend to explore your academic and intellectual interests at the University of Pennsylvania. -University of Pennsylvania

## **EXTRACURRICULAR ESSAY COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. Briefly elaborate on one of your extracurricular activities or work experiences. -Stanford University
2. Please briefly elaborate on one of your extracurricular activities or work experiences. -Rice University
3. If you could only do one of the activities you have listed in the Activities section of your Common Application, which one would you keep doing? Why? -University of Michigan
4. What would you say is your greatest talent or skill? How have you developed and demonstrated that talent over time? -UC Personal Insight Question

## **'DESIGN A COURSE' COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. You are teaching a Yale course. What is it called? -Yale University  
Pomona's Critical Inquiry course is required of all first-year students, and is designed to be highly interdisciplinary and engaging. Recent class titles include: 'Molecules of the Mind', 'The Economics of Sin', and 'Punk: Poets, Politics and Provocation'. Imagine you were hired to design and teach a Critical Inquiry course. Describe the title of the class, its contents, and why you chose it. -Pomona College

## **DESCRIBE YOURSELF / VALUES-BASED COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).



1. What is something about yourself that is essential to understanding you? -University of Southern California (USC)
2. Describe the most significant challenge you have faced and the steps you have taken to overcome this challenge. How has this challenge affected your academic achievement? -UC Personal Insight Question
3. What matters to you, and why? -Stanford University

## **COMMUNITY COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. Reflect on your engagement with a community to which you belong. How do you feel you have contributed to this community? -Yale University
2. What was the environment in which you were raised? Describe your family, home, neighborhood, or community, and explain how it has shaped you as a person. -University of Texas
3. What have you done to make your school or your community a better place? -UC Personal Insight Question
4. Tech's motto is progress and service. We find that students who ultimately have a broad impact first had a significant one at home. What is your role in your immediate or extended family? AND how you seen evidence of your impact on them? -Georgia Tech
5. Everyone belongs to many different communities and/or groups defined by (among other things) shared geography, religion, ethnicity, income, cuisine, interest, race, ideology, or intellectual heritage. Choose one of the communities to which you belong, and describe that community and your place within it. -University of Michigan

## **DIVERSITY COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. The quality of Rice's academic life and the Residential College System are heavily influenced by the unique life experiences and traditions each student brings. What perspective do you feel that you will contribute to life at Rice? -Rice University
2. The late Rev. Theodore M. Hesburgh, C.S.C., Notre Dame's president from 1953 to 1987, served as a trusted adviser to U.S. presidents and popes. A champion for human rights, Fr. Hesburgh was one of the architects of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, which outlawed discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, or national origin. Reflect on the current state of civil rights, the progress that has been made, or the problems still being faced today. -University of Notre Dame
3. SMU is a diverse learning environment shaped by the convergence of ideas and cultures. How will your unique experiences or background enhance the University, and how will you benefit from this community? -Southern Methodist University
4. Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story. -Harvard University
5. Duke University seeks a talented, engaged student body that embodies the wide range of human experience; we believe that the diversity of our students makes our community stronger. If you'd like to share a perspective you bring or experiences you've had to help us understand you better—perhaps related to a community you belong to, your sexual orientation or gender identity, or your family or cultural background—we encourage you to do so. Real people are reading your application, and we want to do our best to understand and appreciate the real people applying to Duke. -Duke University
6. Reflect on your unique background and tell us about a time when you had to relate to someone whose life experience was very different from your own. How did you approach the difference? If put in a similar situation again today, would you respond differently? If so, how? -University of Colorado
7. Nelson Mandela believed that "what counts in life is not the mere fact that we have lived. It is what difference we have made to the lives of others that will determine the significance of the life we lead." Describe a way in which you have made or hope to make a difference. 200-250 words. -Tufts University

## **CAMPUS LIFE COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. Suite-style living - four to six students sharing a set of rooms - may be an integral part of your Yale College experience. What would you contribute to the dynamic of your suite? -Yale University
2. Virtually all of Stanford's undergraduates live on campus. Write a note to your future roommate that reveals something about you or that will help your roommate -- and us -- know you better. (250 word limit) -Stanford University
3. List a few words or phrases that describe your ideal college community. -Columbia University

## **LEADERSHIP COLLEGE ESSAY PROMPTS**

**IMPORTANT:** Some of the prompts below may have changed, and others will change each year, so be sure to check the Common App or particular school's website after Aug. 15 (by which point most prompts are usually released for that year).

1. Describe how your experiences, perspectives, talents, and/or your involvement in leadership activities (at your school, job, community, or within your family) will help you to make an impact both in and out of the classroom while enrolled at UT. -University of Texas
2. Describe an example of your leadership experience in which you have positively influenced others, helped resolve disputes or contributed to group efforts over time. -UC Personal Insight Question